

HB 2872 -- ELEMENTARY STUDENT LITERACY

SPONSOR: Loy

This bill creates, repeals, and modifies provisions relating to literacy of elementary school students.

EDUCATOR PREPARATION PROGRAMS

(Sections 161.097 and 186.080, RSMo.)

The bill requires educator preparation programs to instruct teacher candidates on the selection and use of "high-quality" reading curricula and instructional materials that do not include the three-cueing system, as defined in current law.

This bill prohibits educator preparation programs from including instruction in, or endorsement of, the three-cueing system.

The bill repeals provisions establishing the literacy advisory council and allowing for its recommendations to the Commissioner of Education and the State Board of Education.

The bill also repeals a requirement for teacher candidates to be instructed on best practices in the field of literacy instruction as recommended by the literacy advisory council.

Beginning July 1, 2027, the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education (DESE) must annually review and publicly report on the compliance of educator preparation programs with literacy and reading instruction requirements of current law and those established in the bill. The review must evaluate whether instruction is grounded in the components of evidence-based reading instruction and whether prohibited practices, such as the three-cueing system, are excluded from coursework. Educator preparation programs not in compliance with these requirements will not be approved to certify new teachers.

STATE AID FOR READING INSTRUCTION

(Section 161.241)

The bill provides that the current Evidence-Based Reading Instruction Program Fund may be used to fund reading tutoring programs inside regular school hours, rather than only outside regular school hours.

Subject to appropriation, DESE will remit to each school district and charter school \$500 for each fourth grade student who exhibited a substantial reading deficiency in any of grades kindergarten to grade three, or who was identified as dyslexic, and who subsequently scores at the proficient level or higher in reading on the annual summative English language arts assessment administered to fourth grade students.

IDENTIFICATION OF READING DEFICIENCIES (Sections 167.268, 167.340, and 167.645)

The bill establishes the "Missouri Universal Reading Screener", a uniform, universal, literacy-based reading assessment administered to students in grade one through grade three. The screening must be administered three times per year in every school district and charter school in the State . The screener will score each student in one of the following categories: "below basic", "basic", "grade-level", "proficient", or "advanced". Proficiency benchmarks associated with these categories will be determined by DESE.

Each school district and charter school must assess all students in grade one through grade three on the Missouri Universal Reading Screener during three annual administration windows established by DESE. DESE will provide the screener to school districts and charter schools at no cost. The screener may also be used to comply with dyslexia screening requirements established in current law. Student results on the screener must not be used to make decisions concerning the accreditation of a public school or school district.

The bill repeals a provision requiring school districts and charter schools to assess newly enrolled students in grade one through grade five on a reading assessment selected from a state-approved list.

A student who scores "basic" on the Missouri Universal Reading Screener shall be identified as having a reading deficiency. A student who scores "below basic" on the screener shall be identified as having a substantial reading deficiency.

Beginning with the 2027-28 school year, a school district or charter school must notify the parent of a student with a substantial reading deficiency that if the child's substantial reading deficiency is not corrected by the end of third grade, the child will not be promoted to fourth grade unless the child qualifies for a good cause exemption. Retention of a third-grade

student with a substantial reading deficiency is mandatory unless the child qualifies for a good cause exemption or scores "basic" or higher on a retest opportunity through the Missouri Universal Reading Screener, as specified in the bill.

A good cause exemption may be granted to students who are English language learners or who have individualized education plans or 504 plans developed under federal law. A good cause exemption may also be granted to a student who has already been retained at least once in kindergarten to third grade.

To request a good cause exemption, a student's teacher must submit documentation to the school principal recommending the student's promotion, including the type of exemption being requested and the child's existing reading improvement plan or individualized education plan, as appropriate. The school principal must discuss the recommendation with the teacher and determine whether the student qualifies for a good cause exemption. If the school principal determines that the student qualifies for the good cause exemption, the school principal will make the recommendation in writing to the superintendent, who shall accept or reject the school principal's recommendation in writing.

The school district shall assist schools with notifying parents of students who are retained of the reasons for the retention, along with a description of the proposed interventions and supports that will be provided to the child to remedy the identified area or areas of reading deficiency in the following school year.

Intensive reading instruction provided to students exhibiting a reading deficiency or substantial reading deficiency cannot include the three-cueing system, as defined in current law, to teach word reading.

By October 1 annually, each school board must submit a written report to DESE that contains certain information regarding reading instruction, such as the board's policies regarding student retention and promotion, the number and percentage of students identified as having reading deficiencies or substantial reading deficiencies, the number and percentage of all students retained in kindergarten to third grade due to substantial reading deficiencies, and the total number and percentage of third-grade students who were promoted with good cause exemptions, as specified in the bill.

THREE-CUEING SYSTEM MODEL OF READING INSTRUCTION
(Section 170.014)

Current law provides that instruction in word reading cannot rely primarily on the "three-cueing system", defined as any model of reading instruction based on meaning, structure and syntax, and visual cues, also be known as "MSV". The bill repeals this provision and instead provides that instruction in word reading shall not use the three-cueing system in any form.

This bill is similar to SB 1442 (2026).